

refrain

The line or lines that are repeated in a piece of music, for example the chorus of a song.

Renaissance

The period between 1400 and 1600.

repertoire

The range of works an individual or group is able to perform, or the range of works in a genre.

Requiem

A piece of music written as a memorial, or a musical setting of a Requiem Mass celebrating the dead.

rest

A gap in the music, when the player or singer does not produce any sound. As with note values, there are symbols that indicate how long a rest should be held.

rhythm

The pattern of relative durations and stresses on the notes of a piece of music, commonly organized into measures.

rhythm section

In popular and jazz music, instruments that focus on the rhythm and accompaniment rather than the melody.

riff

A short, repeated series of notes, that forms part of the melody.

Romantic

The period between 1820 and 1900.

rondo

A musical form in which the first section recurs several times.

sample

A short extract from an existing recording that is used in a new recording.

scale

A series of notes that define the key of a piece.

score

A musical composition in written or printed form showing all the parts on separate staves.

serenade

A love song or a calm, light piece of music.

serialism

A system of atonal composition that uses fixed sequences of the 12 notes of the chromatic scale.

sharp

A note that has been raised by a half step. Also describes an instrument that is out of tune by being higher than the intended pitch.

slur

To perform a series of notes smoothly, without breaks between each note.

solo

A piece or section of a piece performed by an individual instrument or voice.

sonata

An instrumental piece in several movements for one or more players.

song

Text set to music for vocal performance.

sonority

The quality of sounding deep and rich.

soprano

The highest of the four standard singing voices.

staccato

A performance technique whereby each note is very short and clipped.

staff

The grid of five horizontal lines on which music is written.

string quartet

An ensemble of four musicians playing stringed instruments, usually a first and second violin, a viola, and a cello.

suite

A work, usually instrumental, made up of several movements. In Baroque music, these are typically contrasting dance movements all in the same key.

suspension

A note that is held, often creating a dissonance, before being resolved by falling to the next note down.

symphony

A large-scale work for full orchestra, usually in three or more movements.

syncopation

Accentuation of a subordinate beat rather than the main beat.

tango

Argentinian dance form and music with its roots in African dance and rhythms.

tempo

The pace of a work, usually indicated in beats per minute.

tenor

The second highest adult male voice after alto, or an instrument that sounds in this range.

tessitura

The range that occurs most often within a piece of music.

theme

A simple melody used as a motif.

tie

A curved line used in musical notation that connects the heads of two notes of the same pitch and indicates that they should be played as a single note.

timbre

The particular quality of a sound that allows a listener

to distinguish one instrument or voice from another.

time signature

The numbers that indicate the number and note value of beats in a measure.

tonality

The system of major and minor scales and keys that forms the basis of Western music.

tone

The quality or timbre of a pitch sounded.

tonic

The first note of any diatonic scale. Also called the keynote.

transcription

Writing music down.

transposition

The setting of a melody into a different key.

treble

The highest unbroken male voice. The highest instrument or part in a piece of music. The treble clef indicates the notes above Middle C on the piano.

tremolo

The rapid repetition of a single note to create a trembling effect.

triad

A chord of three notes, which can be broken down into two intervals of a third.

trill

An ornament involving the rapid alternation of two adjacent notes.

trio

A group of three musicians or voices. The second section of a piece in minuet and trio form.

whole step

An interval that consists of two half steps.